

800–1453

THE EAST IN THE WEST

In medieval times the Mediterranean basin was the most advanced centre in the world for learning, technology, and trade. The importing of luxury goods into the Mediterranean regions and Northern Europe had a long history, both before and after the age of the Crusades (1095–1291). Expensive textiles came from China along the ancient Silk Road, the great trade route running through Central Asia. Eastern weaving techniques made their way to Byzantium and Persia, to Islamic areas in North Africa, and to Al-Andalus, the Moorish kingdom in southern Spain. Venice made its fortune through controlling the trade in luxuries with the Near East. Throughout the Middle Ages the cultures of East and West constantly exchanged and merged styles.



Greek doctor This doctor wears the long robe popular in Orthodox countries, with the fashionable 14th-century fitted torso. The material's pattern of roundels containing animals is typical of high-quality Byzantine silk weaving.



Moorish musician A detail from a mid-13th century illumination, this lutenist combines the Moorish tunic, turban, and beard of Islamic southern Spain with the *pellote* (sleeveless surcoat) then fashionable in Northern Europe.



Crossover style In 13th-century Spain Christians, Muslims, and Jews lived together and influenced each other's clothing. Details, such as the side lacing on this musician's tunic, show how they blended into an "Iberian" style.